

WHY IT WORKS

PREP is a structured way to make a point clearly: state the point, give one reason, show one example, then return to the point. It works because it hands the listener the thing that matters first, then the support for it, so they spend no effort decoding where you are going. That lowers cognitive load, keeps the reason and example in a sensible order, and lets the person understand, decide or act without wading through everything in your head. Used lightly, it organises your thinking while you still sound human, responsive and respectful.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- PREP is not a script to recite mechanically, and you never name the framework out loud.
- It is not a way to avoid listening, or to compress someone's emotion into a template.
- It is not a tool for forcing the other person into your structure.
- If the structure makes the conversation less humane, it is the wrong move — slow down and say it plainly.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: "I know exactly what they're saying, and why."

Principle: People follow a point more easily when they are handed the point first and the support second — not the other way around.

What you gain

- Clarity — the listener knows what matters first.
- Lower cognitive load — less to hold in their head.
- Better sequencing — reason and example arrive in order.
- Faster decisions — they can act without decoding you.
- Credibility — you sound organised, not rehearsed.
- Respect — you're not making them dig for the point.

Why most people fail at it

- They name the framework out loud and it sounds like a technique.
- They deliver it mechanically, forcing every sentence into the template.
- They keep talking after the point has landed.
- They reach for structure when the moment actually needed listening or validation.

CORE FORMULA

Point -> Reason -> Example -> Point -> My point is X. The reason is Y. For example, Z. So the short answer is X. -> Point: lead with the one thing that matters. -> Reason: give the single strongest why, not every why. -> Example: make it concrete with one case, not three. -> Best field rule: use the structure to organise thought, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

State your point in one sentence, give one reason, offer one concrete example, then land back on the point — without ever naming the framework.

BEST FOR

- Concise recommendations
- Explaining a decision or your reasoning
- Meeting contributions

- Interview answers
- Making a scannable point in an email
- Answering "what do you think?" without rambling

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. 1 — Choose the moment

Decide whether structure serves this moment at all. If emotion is high, or the person needs to be heard first, skip the framework and listen. PREP is for when someone wants a clear point, a recommendation or an answer — not when they want comfort.

2. 2 — Point

Lead with the single thing that matters, in one plain sentence. Say it before the reasoning, not after. "I'd move the launch a week" — not three minutes of background that finally arrives at the point.

3. 3 — Reason

Give the one strongest why, not every why. A single clear reason is more persuasive than five stacked ones, and it keeps the listener with you. "Testing is a step behind."

4. 4 — Example

Make it concrete with one example, not three. One vivid case does the work; a pile of examples buries the point. "Staging failed twice this week."

5. 5 — Return to the point, then check

Land back on the point in a few words, then stop and watch. Are they clearer, more engaged, able to act? If they look confused or resistant, summarise and invite correction rather than pushing the structure harder.

FIELD TIP

Scaffolding, not the conversation.

Use PREP to organise your thinking before you speak, then let it disappear. The other person should feel clarity, not choreography. If they can't tell you used a framework, you used it well.

Situation: "I'd move the launch a week — testing's a step behind and staging failed twice. A week gives us a clean run."

Don't: Announce "I'll use PREP here," or repeat the point once it has clearly landed.

Do: Lead with the point, back it with one reason and one example, then stop.

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers • One-line starters

- "Short version?"
- "My point is this."
- "Here's the one thing that matters."
- "Bottom line first, then the why."
- "Let me keep this to a sentence."
- "One point, one reason, one example."
- "The headline is X."
- "Quick answer: X. Want the reasoning?"

Meetings & recommendations • Work contexts

- "My recommendation is X. The reason is Y. For example, Z. So my vote is X."
- "The point is we should move the deadline. Testing isn't ready — staging failed twice this week. So I'd push it a week."
- "In short, I'd go with option B: it's cheaper to run, and the March trial proved that out."
- "My read is we're aligned on scope, just not on timing."
- "One point for the record: the risk sits in the handover, not the build."
- "Here's my answer, the reason behind it, and one example — then I'll stop."
- "I'll give you a recommendation and a reason, and leave the decision with you."
- "The main point is X; everything else is just support for it."

Clear point, clear ask · Firm and plain

- "My point is I can't take this on this week."
- "Short answer: no. Here's the one reason why."
- "Let me give you the point before the detail."
- "Here's what I think, and the single reason I think it."
- "I'll make the point once, clearly, then it's yours."
- "The point stands on one example — here it is."
- "That's my position. Reason and example if you want them."

Collaborative framing · Open and easy

- "Can I give you the short version, then fill in whatever's useful?"
- "I'll keep this simple and we can dig into any part of it."
- "Here's where I've landed — tell me if I've missed something."
- "Let me lay it out plainly, then it's over to you."
- "I want to be clear, not to lecture — pull me up if I overdo it."
- "Short and rough first, then we refine it together."

When it lands as a speech · Soften and simplify

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That came out like a mini-speech. The real point is just X."
- "Let me back up — I don't think that was the useful frame."
- "I don't want the structure to bury the actual issue."
- "Which part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "Sorry, I over-explained. Short version: X."

Under pressure · Check before you structure

- "Before I lay this out — is now the moment, or do you need something else first?"
- "I can give you the clean version, but say if you'd rather just talk it through."
- "Let me check this frame is useful before I run with it."
- "I'll make one point and stop, because I know this matters."
- "If the tidy answer feels cold here, tell me and I'll drop it."
- "One point, then I'll listen — I don't want to talk over this."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Recites PREP as a visible script and sounds rehearsed.

Better: Uses PREP silently to organise a concise response.

Best: Uses PREP flexibly, then checks whether the listener is clearer, more heard, or better able to respond.

2. Weak: Announces "I'll use PREP here" out loud.

Better: Drops the label and just makes the point cleanly.

Best: Structure is invisible; it sounds like a clear person thinking well.

3. Weak: Piles on three examples and loses the point.

Better: Gives one example that fits.

Best: Picks the single example that makes the point land, then returns to it.

DECISION TREE

If The listener needs speed

Use the shortest version — the point alone, BLUF-level brevity.

"Short answer: move it a week. Detail if you want it."

If The listener needs convincing

Use the full Point -> Reason -> Example -> Point.

"Move it a week — testing's behind, staging failed twice. So a week."

If The listener needs support

Validate first and delay the framework.

"This deadline's brutal, I know. Can I say what I think we do?"

If The listener needs a story

Switch to an example-led neighbour such as STAR or CARL.

"Let me walk you through what actually happened last time."

If The listener needs action

End with one clean next step.

"So the next step is: re-test payments today, hold the date."

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Make your contribution concise and memorable — one point, one reason, one example, then hand back. — "I'd hold the date. The risk is only in payments, and we can re-test that today."

Email

Put the framework into short, scannable paragraphs or bullets so the reader gets the point on first pass. —

"Recommendation: push a week. Reason: testing's behind. Example: staging failed twice. Net: a week."

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback would help before you structure it — don't lead with a tidy framework into an open wound. —

"Want the quick version or the full picture? Either's fine."

Difficult conversation

Use one sentence per step, then pause. Let the structure hold you steady without turning it into a wall. — "My point is I need to change how we split this. Here's why, then I'll stop."

Interview answer

Answer the question, give your reason, offer one concrete example, then close on the answer — don't drift. — "Yes. My strength is untangling messy problems — for instance, the migration last year — so that's where I'd add value."

Quick update to a busy manager

Lead with the point and the one thing they need to know; skip the build-up entirely. — "We're on track bar one risk — payments testing — and I've got a plan for it."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

Manager: "What do you think — should we move the launch?"

You: "My point is we should move the launch. The reason is the build isn't ready. For example, testing is behind. So my point is we should move the launch."

Manager: "Right. You said that twice."

You: "To structure it: Point, Reason, Example, Point. The reason again is testing—"

Why it's weak:

announces and repeats the framework

forces every sentence into the template

keeps going after the point has clearly landed

sounds rehearsed instead of thought-through

With the technique

Manager: "What do you think — should we move the launch?"

You: "I'd move it a week. The build's solid but testing's a step behind — staging failed twice this week. A week buys us a clean run."

Manager: "A week's a lot. Can we do less?"

You: "Fair. The real risk is the payment flow, not the whole build. If we just re-test that, we could hold the date."

Manager: "Let's do that."

Why this works:

leads with the point, then one reason, one example

never names the framework

drops the structure the moment the manager needs something different

stays a conversation, not a presentation
The structure is doing its job when you can abandon it mid-answer and the point still stands.

COMMON MISTAKES

Over-structuring — making the framework more important than the point.

Sounds like: "Point one. Reason. Example. And back to my point?"

Better: "I'd move the launch — testing's behind."

Naming the framework out loud.

Sounds like: "Let me PREP this for you."

Better: Just make the point cleanly and drop the label.

Over-explaining after the point has landed.

Sounds like: "?and also, for context, back in Q1?"

Better: Stop once they're clear and hand it back.

Repeating the point when nobody needed it repeated.

Sounds like: "So, again, my point is?"

Better: Say it once, well, and let it sit.

Structuring when emotion or listening should come first.

Sounds like: "Let me lay this out clearly:" (to someone upset)

Better: "That sounds hard. Tell me what happened."

Piling on examples to prove the point.

Sounds like: "For example? and another example? and also?"

Better: Pick the one example that lands.

Skiping the check that the listener is actually clearer.

Sounds like: Delivering the point and moving straight on.

Better: "Does that answer it, or have I missed the bit you care about?"

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- They become clearer or more decisive.
- They ask a sharper, more specific question.
- They summarise your point back accurately.
- They can choose a next step.
- They relax because they can see where you're going.
- The exchange gets shorter, not longer.

Signs to adjust

- They look confused or go quiet.
- They challenge the framing itself.
- They seem to need the human context before the structure.
- You're still talking after the point has landed.
- It starts to sound defensive, performative or salesy.
- It's tipping into a lecture — stop and hand back.
- Emotion is rising and the tidiness feels cold — validate first.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- High-emotion moments
- Active conflict
- Exploratory listening, where you should be drawing them out
- When the other person needs validation first
- Sensitive material — shame, grief, anger or distress
- Real power imbalance or a high-stakes decision, where care matters more than tidiness

- When physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: That came out like a mini-speech — the real point is just X.

- "I made that too structured — let me say it more simply."
- "That may not be the useful frame. Let me back up."
- "I don't want the structure to override the actual issue."
- "What part of that was useful, and what should we drop?"
- "That came out like a mini-speech — the real point is just X."
- "Sorry, I over-explained. Short version: X."
- "Let me stop structuring and just listen for a minute."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Clarity check

PREP -> Summary check

Make the point cleanly.

"Just so we're aligned — what did you take from that?"

Fix any gap before moving on.

Point into ask

PREP -> Clean request

"I'd move the launch a week — testing's behind."

"So, concretely: can you push the announce date to the 14th?"

Point then room

PREP -> Autonomy release

Make the point and give the reason.

"That's my read, but it's your call."

Feelings first

Validation -> PREP

"Yeah, this deadline's brutal — I get it."

Then: "Here's what I think we do, and why?"

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC044 — BLUF

BLUF: both lead with the point. Use PREP when you also need a reason and an example to convince; use BLUF when the bottom line alone is enough.

TC047 — STAR

STAR structures a story (Situation, Task, Action, Result). Use PREP for a crisp recommendation; use STAR when the listener needs the narrative behind a result.

TC048 — SCQA

SCQA frames a problem before the answer (Situation, Complication, Question, Answer). Use PREP to make a point; use SCQA when you first need to set up why the question matters.

TC049 — CARL

CARL is another story structure (Context, Action, Result, Learning). Use PREP for a concise point; use CARL when reflection or the lesson is the focus.

TC013 — Clean request

Clean request: use PREP when making and supporting a point is the need; use Clean request when the moment really calls for a single specific ask.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Draft it

Take a real topic and write a 60-second answer using Point -> Reason -> Example -> Point.

Day 2 — Cut it

Trim yesterday's answer by a third without losing the core point.

Day 3 — Say it two ways

Read it aloud once as visible structure, once as plain speech — and keep the plain one.

Day 4 — Strip the labels

Remove any "my point is / the reason is / for example" scaffolding and check it still holds together.

Day 5 — One example only

Swap in the single strongest example and delete every other one.

Day 6 — Use it live

Use it once in a real conversation and watch whether the listener actually gets clearer.

Day 7 — Practise the recovery

Rehearse one recovery line for when it lands as a mini-speech — and use it if it does.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I use PREP to serve the listener, not to sound polished?
- Was the core point clear in one sentence?
- Did I keep it concise?
- Did I adapt when the listener needed something else?
- Did I preserve their autonomy and dignity?
- Did clarity actually improve, or did I just sound tidy?